

The Kerala Chronicle

Democracy and its discontents

The machinery of democracy in India rests on an uneasy compact between the citizen and the state. Corruption, that persistent solvent of public trust, has proven remarkably adaptive: where scrutiny tightens in one quarter, influence simply migrates to another. The middleman, once a figure of the defence bazaar, now operates across telecommunications, mining and infrastructure.

Transparency campaigners argue that procurement reform without whistle-blower protection is ornamental. A contract awarded in daylight can still be negotiated in the dark.

A note on language

Readers have written to ask about the vocabulary of civic life. The Malayalam word for democracy is ജനാധിപത്യം, and the newspaper you are holding is a പത്രം. A library is a ഗ്രന്ഥശാല, and knowledge, that oldest of public goods, is അറിവ്.

Books received

A Feast of Vultures, by Josy Joseph, published by HarperCollins India in 2016, remains the most unsparing account of the hidden business of Indian democracy to appear in a decade. Our reviewer calls it essential and exhausting in equal measure.

Also received: three volumes of collected essays on education, or വിദ്യാഭ്യാസം, and a slim book of poems, കവിത, from a small press in Thrissur.

Correspondence

Sir — Your correspondent's account of the arms trade omitted the role of the financial intermediary. The commission does not vanish; it is merely relocated to a jurisdiction where questions are not asked. Truth, or സത്യം, is the first casualty of a well-structured invoice.